

Cisco from Hemlock Lake (*Argyrosomus artedii*) — plate from the Freshwater and Marine Image Bank, University of Washington. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	Slim, bright silver, deeply forked tail, small toothless mouth, and a small fleshy adipose fin between the dorsal and the tail — the mark of a salmonid. Nothing else in these lakes has one.
Size here	8–14 in.
Why it matters	Cisco need cold water that still holds oxygen through the summer. Very few lakes in south-eastern Wisconsin can supply that. Their presence is a direct statement about the quality and depth of Pine Lake’s basin.
Spawn	Very late — November into December, over shallow gravel, often as the lake is cooling toward ice.
Eats	Zooplankton, out in open water. It is a pelagic fish that almost never touches bottom or structure.
Season	

What it means for your fishing

Suspended predators	Through July and August, cisco hold in the cold layer below the thermocline over Pine Lake’s 60–85 ft basin, and the biggest walleye, pike and smallmouth follow them out there. This is why the structure bite can die in high summer while the lake is still full of large fish — they are not on the structure at all.
What to do about it	Watch your electronics over open water between spots 3 and 4 . Marks at 30–45 ft over 70 ft of water in August are usually cisco, and often something larger nearby.
Bait size	Where predators are eating a 10 in silver fish, a 3 in minnow is a poor imitation. Size up in late summer.
Catching them	Mostly incidental. They will take a small jig or spoon fished deep, and they are a known ice-fishing target on lakes that hold them. 10 per day; open all year.
Eating	Excellent, oily and fine-textured. Traditionally smoked.

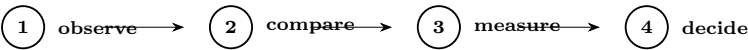
A lesson in the lake

A lake is a stack of layers, not a bowl. In summer Pine Lake has warm water on top, a sharp temperature step in the middle, and cold water below — and different fish live in each. Cisco are the clearest evidence that the bottom layer is alive. Explaining that to a child on the water is worth more than a limit of bluegill.

Worth knowing

They are a thermometer	Cisco need cold water that still holds oxygen through late summer. Their presence in Pine Lake is a direct statement that the deep basin stays oxygenated — something most lakes in southern Wisconsin cannot manage. Where cisco disappear from a lake, it is usually because that layer failed.
A salmonid, not a herring	Despite the name lake herring, the adipose fin gives it away: cisco are in the salmon and trout family. That is why they are oily and why they smoke so well. <i>see the Cooking Cisco sheet</i>
They spawn under your ice	Spawning happens in November and December over shallow gravel, sometimes as the lake is freezing — the latest spawn of any fish in this guide by months.
They filter the open water	Cisco eat zooplankton in open water, converting the smallest thing in the lake into a 10 in packet of protein that a walleye can eat. They are the link between the plankton and the predators.
Which is where the big fish go	In July and August the largest predators in Pine Lake follow cisco out over the basin, and structure fishing goes quiet while the lake is still full of fish. Watch for marks at 30–45 ft over 70 ft of water.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Is there a small fleshy adipose fin between the dorsal fin and deeply forked tail?
Rule out	Shiners and young perch lack an adipose fin; whitefish have a more projecting snout and different body depth.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: support the soft body on a wet board and read without squeezing.
Field proof	Adipose fin, forked tail, and small toothless mouth must appear together. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

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